

The Multifaceted Irony in *Beowulf*

Similar to epic poems in other cultures, *Beowulf* is a work of irony. The poet constructs the irony by accommodating unlikely coexistence of opposite elements, reversing and subverting audience's expectations and adopting sarcastic literary styles from skaldic poetry. By alternating between narratives from the Christian and pagan perspectives and appealing to the common concepts or stories, the poet maintains an improbable equilibrium between the two religions. Moreover, the poet constructs simultaneous and seemingly contradictory comparisons between Beowulf and the glorified hero Sigmund as well as the fallen warrior Heremod. The divergent yet reconciled elements in the poem subvert and satirize rigid categorizations of religions and heroic codes. In addition to challenging the rigorous religious reading and the perception of perfect heroes, the poet actively upsets audience's anticipation by introducing multiple misnomers, reversing characters' roles and resolving recurrent themes in distinct ways. Furthermore, the poet artistically reconstructs the story by utilizing figurative devices from skaldic poetry and creating anachronisms. This style that focuses more on the efficacy of expression than on the factual details allows the reshaping of characters to reflect and challenge real-world scenarios.

Reconciling competing parallelisms and metaphors in a coherent framework, the poet creates the irony of viable interpretations from opposite perspectives. The most prominent example of this duality is the concoction of the paganism and the Christianity in the same event. One technique that the poet employs to allow multiple meanings is combining various elements from the Norse mythology and the Bible to describe an action. When Hrothgar builds Heorot, the poet uses words akin to those in the Book of Genesis to praise the wonder of this imposing and sumptuous hall: "He, victory-creative, set out the brightness / of sun and moon as lamps for earth

dwellers, / adorned the green fields, the earth, with branches, / shoots, and green leaves; and life He created, / in each of the species which live and move” (ll. 94--98). This acclaim is mainly Christian because the creation is a highlight in the Bible, while the interactions between the ice and the fire, not divine plans, that introduces life into the world. However, Heorot, as a grand mead-hall, represents pagan ideals more than Christian spirits that promotes harmony instead of a jubilant cacophony. The activities in Heorot is reminiscent of the entertainment in the legendary Valhalla: “Happy laughter loud in the hall, / the thrum of the harp, melodious chant, / clear song of the scop” (ll. 88--90). Furthermore, similar to the Einherjar that reside in Valhalla, the occupants in Heorot are described as “the brave warriors” (ll. 100). Just as Valhalla that is doomed to be burned to ash in the Ragnarok, Heorot, as the narrator foresees, “awaited the war-flames, / malicious burning” (ll. 82--83). Despite this close link with the lore in the Norse mythology, the narrator attributes Grendel’s hating Danes and terrorizing Heorot to Cain’s killing Abel, the renowned first murder in the Bible. In addition, when Hrothgar prays to heathen gods for protection, the narrator even points out the futility directly: “Woe unto him / who in violent affliction has to thrust his soul / in the fire’s embrace, expects no help, / no change in his fate!” (ll. 183--186). This rapid switch between elements in different religions blurs the distinction between two opposite interpretations and establish the irony of the coexistence of the Christianity and the paganism.

In addition to incorporating elements from divergent myths, the poet maintains the ironic equilibrium between two religions by appealing to their common concepts. One notable example is the similar spellings of Hel, the ruler of the underworld in the Norse mythology and Hell, the infernal place where sinners are punished in Christian belief. The poet invokes the common idea of the dark netherworld in both myths to create a picture of ill omens and hopelessness.

Moreover, acknowledging the existence of the supreme divinity, both religions regard their highest deity as the “all-father” or “ruler of skies.” Though the references in the poem where a supernatural being controls the course of events seem mainly Christian¹, a weaker pagan reading is reasonable in most cases. For example, in Beowulf’s battle with Grendel’s mother, the narrator comments “Holy God / controlled the fight, the mighty Lord / Ruler of skies, decided it rightly” (ll. 1553--1555). With the help from the divinity, Beowulf is gifted “a victory-bright blade” (ll. 1557), which he wields to decapitate Grendel’s mother. From the Christian perspective, one may conclude that God appreciates Beowulf’s unrivaled might and unwavering determination to vanquish monsters, and therefore ensures his victory over evil by granting him an exquisite sword. However, gifting swords to beloved heroes is also practiced by Odin. Awarding Sigmund a sword that brings victory and guiding Sigurd to reforge its fragments into the renowned Gram that kills the dragon Fafnir, Odin assists heroes to complete their missions by bestowing fine weapons. This ambiguous reference to the highest divinity also occurs when Beowulf worries that he might have offended God, “To the good king / it was great anguish, pain deep in mind. / The wise man believed he had angered God, / the Eternal Ruler, very bitterly, / had broken the old law” (ll. 2327--2331). Though the poem does not mention the sins he commits in his rule, Beowulf dies in the following battle may not be brought about by his falling out of favor. Both God and Odin have caused ordeal or even death to their cherished heroes. In the Book of Job, Job has to suffer an unwanted loss to prove his allegiance to God. In the Poetic Edda, Odin helps kill his beloved warriors to welcome them to Valhalla. Therefore, Sigmund dies in the battle because of the shattering of his most trusted sword, Helgi Hundingsbane is killed by a spear lent

¹ In the Norse mythology, Odin is far from being omnipotent. For example, he has to sacrifice one eye to drink from the well of wisdom. In the Ragnarok, he fails to defeat Fenrir and dies in the battle.

by Odin, and Sinfjǫtli is taken to another world on a boat. Invoking the common ideas present in both religions, the poet accommodates interpretations of certain passages in opposite ways.

Apart from the common concepts, the poet establishes the ironic coexistence of the paganism and the Christianity by incorporating into the poem similar lore in two religions. After Beowulf presents the hilt of the sword to Hrothgar, the Danish king finds that “There was engraved / the origin of past strife, when the flood drowned, / the pouring ocean killed the race of giants. / Terribly they suffered were a people strange / to eternal God” (ll. 1688--1692). A Christian interpretation of this passage could be that the giants are referring to the Nephilim before the Deluge. Similarly, in the Norse mythology, the long-lasting feud between gods and giants starts when Odin and his brothers slay Ymir, whose blood caused a flood that drowns most of the giants. Moreover, the pagan reading does not meet the problem where the root of the conflict between Grendel’s family and the Danish royal family changes from Cain’s killing Abel to the flooding of Nephilims. Later in the poem, Beowulf recollects Hrethel’s mourning Herebeald: “So it is bitter for an old man / to have seen his son go riding high, / young on the gallows; then may he tell / a true sorrow-song, when his son swings, / a joy to the raven, and old and wise / and sad, he cannot help him at all.” In the Bible, the death of the beloved sons brings profound sorrow to King David and even God himself. Similarly, in the Prose Edda, the killing of well-loved Baldur deeply grieves Odin and Frigg, in *Njal’s Saga*, the murder of Hoskuld drowns Njal with relentless mental sufferings, and in *Egil’s Saga*, the death of Bodvar drives the intrepid hero Egil into despair. Because of the presence of similar stories in both religious teachings, the flooding of the giants and the loss of beloved sons appeal to both Christian and pagan audience.

Within each religious frame, the poet creates another layer of irony by parodying the famous scenes in the canonical teaching. Similar to Jesus and twelve Apostles, Beowulf leads a team of eleven warriors and a servant to fight against the awakened dragon. Just as Judas's betrayal resulted in the arrest and crucifixion of Jesus, the theft committed by the servant places Beowulf in an unavoidable and fatal battle. Likewise, the fleeing from the battlefield of ten retainers on seeing Beowulf's danger in the fight against the dragon resembles the dispersal of Apostles after Jesus's capture. On the other hand, this final battle parallels the clash during the Ragnarok, where twelve Æsir gods have to fight in a doomed strife because of the betrayal of the thirteenth god Loki. Like Thor who falls dead after staggering back nine steps despite his victory over the Midgard Serpent, Beowulf passes away shortly after vanquishing the dragon.

Throughout the poem, the poet makes several ironic comparisons between Thor and Beowulf. Both Beowulf and Thor are accomplished warriors and renowned for their physical strength. In *Lokasenna*, Thor overcomes Loki's flaunts by displaying his virility, and similarly, Beowulf overpowers Unferth by highlighting the courage and stamina involved in fighting sea-monsters. While Thor is tricked many times in the mythology, Beowulf's political wisdom remains in question. Scholar Walter Beverly argues in his thesis "When Beowulf journeys to and within Grendel's mere, he parallels Thor's own adventures to Jotunheim, as they both battle the monsters in their own elements" (39). Jotunheim, similar to Grendel's mere, is governed by a different set of laws. Beverly further observes, "Lerer points out a stronger parallel to Thor's Utgarðr experience, in which Beowulf's fall wrestling Grendel's mother bears resemblance to Thor's while wrestling Elli, the embodiment of old age. Lerer connects the two episodes as examples of a warrior's recognition of his own vulnerability" (38). In addition to the developed parallelism between Thor and Beowulf, the poet makes an ironic comparison between the

weapons they wield. Thor highly values his weapon Mjǫlnir, the only flaw of which is the short handle. Ironically, when Beowulf retrieves “a victory-bright blade” from Grendel’s mere (ll. 1557), the beautifully-carved hilt is all that remains.

Akin to the reconciliation of interpretations of events based on two distinct religions, the simultaneous comparison of Beowulf to acclaimed Sigmund and condemned Heremod is infused with the poet’s irony with regard to the Geatish hero’s fate. The parallelism between Sigmund and Beowulf is explicit. After Beowulf overpowers Grendel, a Danish scop “began to recite Beowulf’s praise, / a well-made lay of his glorious dead” (ll. 872--873). However, instead of describing the fierce fight between Beowulf and Grendel, the scop “skillfully varied his matter and style” and sings about Sigmund and Heremod (ll. 874). While Sigmund is described as “the greatest champion and king in ancient times” (Saga 51), the narrator comments “many kept saying / that north or south, between the two seas, / across the whole earth, no other man / under heaven’s vault, of all shield-holders, / could ever be better, more worthy of kingdoms” (ll. 857--861). Just as Sigmund is granted a fine sword that brings victory, Beowulf lays hands on an ancient blade that decapitates Grendel’s mother. Despite his glorious achievements, Sigmund falls on the battlefield after his sword breaks. Likewise, in spite of the peaceful rule for fifty years, Beowulf dies shortly after Nægling is shattered in the fight against the dragon. In contrast to the similar fate shared by Sigmund and Beowulf, the parallelism with Heremod seems unlikely. Twice Heremod is described as a failure that the Geatish hero should be wary of, the first time by the Danish scop and the second time by Hrothgar before Beowulf’s departure. Instead of juxtaposing the heroic achievements, the poet makes an implicit comparison of Heremod’s and Beowulf’s personalities. As a mighty and promising warrior at his early age, Heremod becomes a victim to his pride: “his portion of arrogance / begins to increase, when his

guardian sleeps, / bound up in cares” (ll. 1740--1742). Describing Beowulf’s growing confidence in his physical strength, the poet implies that Beowulf might have let down his vigilance and allowed the arrogance to increase. When Beowulf, in his youth, fights against Grendel, he still welcomes help from his companions, but facing a more dangerous foe, the seasoned Geatish king unexpectedly dismisses all of his followers and insists on taking on the fight alone. The repetition of the warning against the corrupting influence of Heremod, especially the second time by Hrothgar, implies that the experienced Danish king might have detected increasing vanity in the young warrior. Because of his blind belief in his capabilities, Beowulf picks a few warriors and refuses to form an army to face the dragon: “Then the ring-giver scorned to approach / the dragon with troops, with a full army; he did not fear a fight with the serpent; / its strength and fire seemed nothing at all / to the strong old king” (ll. 2345--2349). Even among these hand-picked soldiers, ten out of eleven choose to run away. At the end of the poem, the contemporaries describe Beowulf as “most eager for fame” (ll.3182). For a warrior, the ambition for heroic deeds is a positive impetus, but for a king, this verdict could be a testimony to Beowulf’s expanding pride. Unlike Sigmund, who relays battles for fame to his sons Helgi and Sinfjötli, Beowulf clenches the opportunity to display physical strength. Therefore, the poet suggests that both Heremod and Beowulf are respectable warriors, but not necessarily successful kings.

In addition to the irony stemming from the juxtaposition of opposite religions and comparisons, the poet achieves sarcastic effects by reversing expectations. For example, the names in the poem are sometimes not indicative of what these name-bearers accomplish. In the beginning, the narrator introduces the legendary Danish king Scyld Scefing. Though his name is related to “shield” in the original language, the Danish king is famous for expanding territory and

winning offensive wars: “Often Scyld Scefing seized mead-benches / from enemy troops, from many a clan; / he terrified warriors” (ll. 4--6). Likewise, as the son of Ecgtheow, whose name means “a slave (servant) to swords,” Beowulf, however, prefers grappling with hands to fighting with swords. The narrator observes, “It was not his fate / that edges of iron might help him in combat. / That hand was too strong, as I have heard, / that broke in its swing every weapon, / wound-hardened sword, that he carried to battle; / he was no better off for all his strength” (ll. 2682--2687). As the son of Ecglaf, whose name means “sword as remainder,” Unferth is willing to risk entrusting Beowulf with the heirloom sword Hrunting, though the Geatish hero’s possible defeat would result in the loss of the sword. Moreover, the Danish queen Wealhtheow, whose name is associated with “a slave (servant) to wealth”, voluntarily gives the precious gold collar without grudge. The narrator specifically comments on the rarity and value of the treasure: “No better treasures, gold gifts to heroes, / were known under heaven since Hama bore off / to shining city the Brosings’ necklace, / gem-figured filigree” (ll. 1197--1200). Modthrytho’s name, associated with the force of will, would perfectly suit the ruthless princess who puts to death anyone for unwanted attention but becomes ill-matched when she transforms into an ideal of queenly virtue after marriage. The scholar Valentine Anthony Pakis argues that “Æschere is a kenning for ‘cremation’ or ‘funeral pyre’” (105). Pakis observes, “It would be ironic, of course, for the Beowulf poet to have named a character ‘cremation, funeral pyre’ whose murderer left no or few remains to burn, but such irony is not foreign to Old English poetry” (112). Pakis further proposes that “the name Æschere was one of these things, that it originated in the tradition represented in Beowulf’s précis to Hygelac, and that it was chosen, like the name Hondscio, to suit its immediate and original poetic context” (110). Since most characters in the poem do not

appear elsewhere, it is possible that the poet intentionally creates misnomers to attain sarcastic purposes.

Besides subverting the meaning of names, the poet reverses the roles different characters assume. Because of Weohstan's loyalty to the usurper Onela and killing Earmund, after Eadgils is restored to the throne with the help of Beowulf, Wiglaf is, in fact, a Swedish outcast residing in Geatland. However, Wiglaf becomes the only retainer that follows Beowulf into the battle. After Beowulf's death, Wiglaf announces the sentence of exile to soldiers who choose to abandon their lord: "each man of your families will have to be exiled" (ll. 2887). Despite his honor and glory in battles, Beowulf is given most prized heirloom treasure that should be passed on to royal descendants and warriors are not entitled to---Heorogar's sword from Hrothgar and Nægling from Hygelac. Later in the poem, Beowulf even ascends to the Geatish throne. Obtaining these treasures seem out of place or even transgressional. In Beowulf's time and later the saga age, legitimate heirs seldom, if ever, relinquish the right of inheritance. In *Laxdaela Saga*, when Hoskuld proposes to give his illegitimate son share of land and cattle, Thorleik vehemently resents the proposal and takes serious offense when Olaf is gifted the exquisite sword and ring. In *Njal's Saga*, because of Njal's partial favor to Hoskuld, Skarphedin and other Njalssons kill the loved foster son under a slight instigation from Mord Valgardsson. Following this reasoning, one may conclude that the impending destruction of Geatland by Swedish after Beowulf's death is a correction of abnormal arrangements.

Moreover, the poet challenges the expectation of audience by resolving recurrent events with divergent outcomes. The poem opens with Scyld's funeral. Conquering and subjugating neighboring land, the legendary Danish king wins accolade and respect from his people and bordering nations. The demise of Scyld is preceded by Denmark's expansion and followed by an

age where the nation prospers. Therefore, his funeral is filled with honor and commemoration. In comparison, the poem closes with Beowulf's funeral. Though attaining unrivaled fame as a warrior and governing Geatland for fifty peaceful years, Beowulf cannot suppress or settle the issues endangering the country for years, such as the feuds with Frisians and Swedish royal families. Consequently, his death leaves a chaotic Geatland that can be preyed upon by other countries and an atmosphere of despair and resignation permeates his funeral. As is recorded in *Heimskringla*, both lords are decorated with a great amount of treasure in the funerals: "Odin decreed by law that all dead men should be burnt, and their goods laid beside them on the pyre, and the ashes thrown in the sea or buried in the ground. He declared that in this way every man would come to Valhøll with as much wealth as he had with him on the pyre." However, Scyld's treasure symbolizes his achievements in conquest and the expansion of the territory: "Great treasure was there, / bright gold and silver, gems from far lands" (ll.36--37); Beowulf's leaving with gold untapped represents an attempt to evade the curse: "The princes of old had sunk the treasure / so deep with spells, buried till Doomsday, / that he who plundered the floor of treasures / would be guilty of sin, tortured by evils, / bound in hell-chains at devil's shrines" (ll. 3069--3073). The complete and cyclic structure constructed by the funeral rites in the beginning and the ending of the poem, however, foreshadows the utterly different fates for Denmark and Geatland.

Furthermore, the poet adopts several figurative devices and styles frequently used for lampooning or exaggerating from skaldic poetry, such as kenning and metaphor. Skaldic poets avoid referring to trivial objects by direct names and instead employs embellished and flamboyant languages. In addition to signifying the trivial objects, the flowery phrases usually contain personal sentiments. For example, in *Egil's Saga*, when Egil seeks to marry Asgerd, he

composes a poem and describes women as “goddess of the arm” to express his admiration and as “head-dress of the rock-giant’s earth” or “sea-fire’s fortress” to satirize the futility of his advances (93). One prominent theme of *Beowulf* is lamenting over the ephemeral nature of life. Therefore, the poet describes the body in materialistic terms, such as “flæsc-hama” (clothing of flesh) (ll. 1568), “bân-hûs” (bone-house) (ll. 2508) and “bân-loca” (the enclosure of bones) (ll. 742). Since the components that form human bodies disintegrate inevitably, life, especially youth withers just as flesh and bones decompose. However, considering the Christian message that spirits persist after the decay of the body, one may find this pessimistic and materialistic view of life cynical and ironic. Moreover, the poet frequently uses expressive and vivid phrases as appositive clauses to help convey the emotions. In the Modthrytho episode, the poet describes the stubborn princess as “þátte freoðu-webbe” (that peace-weaver) (ll. 1942) in an appositive clause. This juxtaposition is sardonic because what Modthrytho does at that time is, far from bringing peace, causing conflicts by putting to death anyone for unwanted attention. In contrast to the flamboyant and colorful language employed in circumlocutions, the poet utilizes the litotes technique, namely, the ironic understatement in which an affirmative is expressed by the negative of its contrary. For example, feeling indignant about the fleeing warriors whose actions contribute to Beowulf’s demise, however, Wiglaf suppresses intense anger and wryly comments, “The king of our land had no need to boast / about armed comrades” (ll. 2873--2874). This intentional downplay of the severity of abandoning lords helps to extricate Beowulf from his mistake of choosing unreliable retainers and awaken the guilt inside them. The wide use of skaldic poetry sarcastic techniques in *Beowulf* helps the narrator and the characters in the poem vent their emotions or make implicit comments.

Another source of the irony is the contradiction within the poem and the occasional anachronism. Similar to the form of *senna* in skaldic poetry, the poet sometimes places the effect of the speech over the factual details. An extreme example of *senna* is in the *Tale of Sarcastic Halli*, where Halli, in response to the challenge that he fails to exact vengeance for his father, fabricates a sensational story that Thjodolf avenges patricide by eating the murderer. Similarly, in his flyting with Unferth, Beowulf's claim of having slain sea-monsters in the swimming competition might not be entirely true. Otherwise, this heroic deed should have cleared the disrepute of being lazy and cowardly: "Yet his youth had been miserable, / when he long seemed sluggish to the Geatish court; / they thought him no good; he got little honor / no gifts on the mead-bench from the lord of the Weders. / They were convinced he was slow, or lazy, / a coward of a noble" (ll. 2182--2188). The observation that Beowulf has a miserable and sluggish youth also contradicts his self-introduction to Hrothgar: "I am Hygelac's thane and kinsman; / mighty the deeds I have done in my youth" (ll. 408--409). Another textual conflict is that despite the narrator never mentions Hygelac's stopping Beowulf from going to Denmark, the Geatish king still claims: "Often I asked you / not to attack that monstrous spirit, / but to let the South-Danes test out Grendel / themselves in battle" (ll. 1994--1997). Likewise, Wiglaf complains about the futility of a non-existent attempt to persuade: "We could not persuade our beloved leader, / our kingdom's shepherd, by any counsel, / not to attack that gold-keeper, / to let him lie where long he had lain, / dwelling in his cave till the end of the world" (ll. 3079--3083).

In addition to the textual conflict, the poet introduces irony into the poem by creating artificial anachronisms, most notably, the manipulation of heroic deeds and figures. In a possible attempt to sanitize the incestuous aspect of the material, the poet introduces Sinfjötli as Sigmund's nephew instead of nephew and son. In order to create an ideal king figure, the poet

attributes Sigurd's killing dragon to his father Sigmund. Moreover, there is a problem in Danish scop's singing about Sigmund. If one were to believe the genealogy of *Njal's Saga*, Hallgerd's father is Hoskuld, whose mother is Thorgerd, the daughter of Olaf the White, the son of Ingjald, the son of Thora, the daughter of Sigurd Snake-in-the-eye, the son of Aslaug, the daughter of Sigurd, then the story of the Volsungs cannot take place before that of *Beowulf*. Therefore, the introduction of Volsungs into the plot might be the poet's attempt of constructing a parallelism between Sigmund and Beowulf. Another possible artistic creation is the legendary Danish king Heremod that exists only in *Beowulf*. He might be Hermóðr in the Norse mythology, who, as the Poetic Edda narrates, receives helm and mail-coat from Odin as opposed to Sigmund who is given sword. In this way, the juxtaposition of the outcome of two warriors valued by gods would better fit into the opposite parallelisms that the poet strives to create. Moreover, in the Modthrytho episode, the poet intentionally blurs the name of the queen and distinction between Offa I and Offa II. By praising the virtue and goodness of the queen, as well as the substantial role Offa plays in bringing about the transformation, the poet possibly aims to please the contemporary ruler Offa II. Scholar Roberta Frank argues, "The poet's sense of anachronism is revealed in his characters' speeches" (55). Frank further observes "The actors themselves have a sense of the past and the future. They are able to look back two generations, tracing the origins of the feud between the Geats and the Swedes (2379--96, 2472--89, 2611--19, 2379--96). They can also forecast the feuds of the next generation" (55) Besides pointing out the fictional nature of contemporary heroes, Frank further claims that the introduction of old heroes into the poem is also a literary technique, "The poet does not make earlier Danish and Germanic heroes like Scyld, Heremod, Finn, Offa, Sigemund, Eormenric and Hama contemporaneous with the sixth century events narrated, but sets them in a distant mirror, conveying the illusion of a many-

storied long-ago” (56). Placing his story in the relatively unknown country Geatland and artistically creates contemporary and ancient figures, the poet constructs a fictional world that reflects and subverts the ethics of the real world.

In conclusion, *Beowulf* is an ironic work that allows unlikely conflicting readings, challenges conventional expectations and adopts skaldic poetry styles. The stylish similarity between skaldic poems and *Beowulf* goes beyond the wide use of metaphor, kenning, and litotes. The poet of *Beowulf*, in most parts of the poem, painstakingly conceals characters’ emotions and thoughts and utilizes understatement. Unlike skaldic poems, *Beowulf* sparkles a few emotional highpoints, including Hrethel’s mourning Herebeald and *Beowulf*’s dark thoughts before the dragon fight. Generally speaking, the main source of the irony in *Beowulf* consists of omnipresent contrasts, between the Christianity and the paganism, between heroes and tyrants, between expectation and actual presentation, and between fact and artistic manipulation.

Works Cited

Beowulf. Translated by Howell D. Chickering, Jr. New York, NY: Anchor Books. 2006. Print.

Beverly, Walter. “The *Beowulf* Poet’s Accommodation of Pre-Christian Germanic Culture.”

ProQuest. 2014. Web.

Frank, Roberta. “*Beowulf* Poet’s Sense of History.” *The Wisdom of poetry; essays in early*

English literature in honor of Morton W. Bloomfield. 1982. Web. 53--65.

Pakis, Valentine. “The Meaning of *Æschere*’s Name in *Beowulf*.” *Journal of English Philology*.

Vol 126, Issue 1. 2008. Web. 104--113.

The Saga of the Volsungs. Translated by Jesse L. Byock. New York, NY: Penguin. 1999. Print.